

Getting into System Administration

Syed admitted that experience was more important than anything else you could do to get a job in System Administration. Then come the certificates. Certifications seem to be a lot more important when getting a job as a system administrator. Even more important than a college degree. When asked about this anomaly Syed said, “A degree has some weightage, but the certifications help the manager to gauge your skills better.”

Balaji Ramarao seems to agree with this statement. He says that three years of certification is more than enough to impress the company. One or two years of work experience would also go a long way. However, even though book knowledge and certification help, to a certain level, a budding SysAdmin should have 2-3 years of on-the-job training, initially.

There are several certifications which are recognised when applying for a job in System Administration:

- ▶ MCSA (Microsoft Certified Solutions Associate) for System Admin/ System Engineer
- ▶ MCITP (Microsoft Certified IT Professional) for System Admin/ System Engineer
- ▶ CCNA (Cisco Certified Network Associate) for Network Admin/ Network Engineer
- ▶ CCNP (Cisco Certified Networking Professional) for Network Admin/ Network Engineer

Other than these, there's also LPIC (Linux Professional Institute Certification 1, 2 and 3), RHCE (Red Hat Certified Engineer), HPASE, HPCSE (HP Accredited Systems Engineer and Certified Systems Engineer), OCP and OCA (Oracle Certified Professional and Oracle System Administrator). Most of these courses, as you can see, are Operating System-specific, which inherently implies that though the job of System Admins may be the same, their specialisation is the lynchpin to their job (i.e. depending on the system that the company's server is built on).

Specialisations

Other than specialisation of the operating systems that run servers, system administrators also specialise in four main fields:

- ▶ **Architects:** System Architects lay out the system of a company from scratch – deciding the foundational operating system that everything would run on and the material required to ensure that things are set up smoothly and making sure that everything is ready before giving the go-ahead.